

Over 30% of our seas protected?

A government claim, tested against EEA boundaries and EU reporting

THE CLAIM

“Malta protects more than 30% of its maritime zone...”

Environment Minister Miriam Dalli, 2025 (as quoted by Amphora Media)

ERA: “more than 35% of Malta’s Fisheries Management Zone”.

We mapped every protected site against all of Malta’s waters.

VERDICT

MISLEADING

*36% within 25 nm;
5.5% of Malta's waters.*

SUPPORTED

LARGELY
SUPPORTED

NOT
SUBSTANTIATED

MISLEADING

CONTRADICTED

MAIN RESULTS

4,138 km²

Protected, as stated

18 marine Natura 2000 sites, all within 25 nautical miles.

36%

Of the fisheries zone

The 25-nm zone ERA names: 15% of the waters Malta reports.

5.5%

Of waters reported to the EU

75,715 km²: the basis for the EU's 30% target.

0 km²

Protected beyond 25 nm

Where 85% of the waters Malta reports to the EU lie.

0.6%

Of the deep sea protected

Waters over 1,000 m deep: a quarter of the total.

FAIR TO SAY

ERA's own page names the fisheries zone, and the EU's 30% is an EU-wide target. The problem is the minister's “maritime zone”, which reads as all of Malta's waters.

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

☐ The minister's full statement.

☐ Malta's basis for the EU target.

☐ Management plans offshore.

☐ Monitoring results.